

The Ethical Hacker's Command Handbook

Chapter 3 – Part 4: Reading, Understanding & Analyzing Exploit Code

Reading exploit code is a research skill that helps you understand vulnerabilities and assess risk.

Learning Objectives

Understand exploit headers, software versions, CVE references, programming languages, dependencies, configuration variables, main logic, and a structured analysis workflow.

Exploit Header

Review the title, author, publication date, EDB-ID, target software, affected version, platform, and CVE before reading the code.

Software Version

Always compare the exploit's target version with the version identified during enumeration.

CVE Reference

Use CVE identifiers to research advisories, affected versions, severity, and mitigations.

Imports & Dependencies

Identify required libraries, packages, or external tools needed by the exploit.

Configuration Variables

Understand expected inputs such as target address, port, timeout, or file path.

Main Logic

Read the overall workflow to understand what the exploit is designed to do.

Output Messages

Review status messages to understand the script's execution flow.

Exploit Analysis Workflow

Searchsploit → Read Header → Verify Software Version → Review CVE → Check Dependencies → Understand Variables → Read Main Logic → Review Output → Document Findings

Section	What to Review
Header	Target, version, platform, CVE
Dependencies	Required libraries and tools

Variables	Expected user inputs
Main Logic	Overall workflow
Output	Status and results

Practice Questions

1. Why should you read the exploit header first?
2. Why must software versions be verified?
3. What can imports and dependencies tell you?
4. What are configuration variables used for?
5. Why is understanding the exploit workflow important?